SOUTH INDIAN COLLECTION

NO. 03



TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Vegetable Kurma

Coconut & Cashew Vegetable Curry

The South Indian Companion to Dosa and Idiyappam

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Vegetable Kurma

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The South's Own Take on a Mughal Classic

Kurma (also spelled korma) traces back to Mughlai cooking traditions of North India, where the term originally described a technique of slow-braising meat in a rich, spiced yogurt or nut-based sauce. As the concept traveled south and adapted to Tamil and broader South Indian kitchens, it transformed considerably — vegetable kurma today bears only a family resemblance to its North Indian namesake, built instead around a coconut and cashew paste rather than yogurt and cream, and seasoned with distinctly South Indian aromatics like curry leaves and whole South Indian spices.

This regional reinvention produced a dish that's become a genuine South Indian breakfast and lunch staple in its own right, most commonly served alongside idiyappam (string hoppers), appam, or dosa — pairings that would be unfamiliar in North Indian korma traditions but feel entirely natural within South Indian meal structures.

The dish's mild, coconut-forward creaminess makes it a popular choice for introducing newcomers to South Indian food, offering comfort and richness without the intense heat found in some other regional curries — a gentle, crowd-pleasing dish that nonetheless carries genuine technique in how its coconut-cashew base is built.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The South's Own Take on a Mughal Classic, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Adapted from North Indian Mughlai korma traditions, transformed with coconut and South Indian spicing into a distinctly regional dish. Most classically paired with idiyappam (string hoppers), appam, or dosa, reflecting South Indian rather than North Indian meal structures. Valued for its mild, comforting creaminess, often serving as an accessible introduction to South Indian food for newcomers. A dish that illustrates how culinary techniques and names travel and transform as they move between Indian regions.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	30m	6	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small blender, for the coconut-cashew paste
- Kadai or wide pan
- Pot, for boiling vegetables

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Vegetable kurma keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days. It freezes reasonably well for up to a month, though the coconut-based gravy may separate slightly on thawing — stir well while reheating gently.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the vegetables

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Carrot, diced	½ cup	60 g	½ katori
Green beans, cut	½ cup	50 g	½ katori
Potato, diced	½ cup	80 g	½ katori
Peas, fresh or frozen	½ cup	70 g	½ katori
Cauliflower florets	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Water, for boiling	1 cup	240 ml	1 katori

For the coconut-cashew paste

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Fresh coconut, grated (or dried, unsweetened)	½ cup	50 g	½ katori
Cashews, raw	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Green chili	2	2	2
Fennel seeds	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Ginger	1 inch	10 g	1 inch
Garlic cloves	3	3	3

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the curry

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Cinnamon stick	1 inch	1 inch	1 inch
Cloves	3	3	3
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Onion, sliced	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Tomato, chopped	1 medium	100 g	1 medium
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Red chili powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Dried, unsweetened coconut works well if fresh isn't available, though fresh gives the best flavor and texture. This dish's vegetable combination is flexible — feel free to substitute based on what's available, such as green peas, bell peppers, or drumstick. The coconut-cashew paste is the heart of the dish and shouldn't be substituted, though the specific vegetables can vary freely.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Base

01 BOIL THE VEGETABLES

Combine the carrot, beans, potato, peas, and cauliflower with water in a pot. Cook until just tender, about 10–12 minutes. Drain and set aside, reserving the cooking water.

02 MAKE THE COCONUT-CASHEW PASTE

Blend the coconut, cashews, green chili, fennel seeds, ginger, and garlic with a little water to a smooth, thick paste.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Base, continued

Chef tip. blend thoroughly for a completely smooth paste — any graininess will carry through into the finished curry.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The coconut-cashew paste should be completely smooth and pale, with no visible coconut texture remaining — this is the base of the kurma's signature creaminess.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Kurma

03 BLOOM THE WHOLE SPICES

Heat oil in a kadai and add the cinnamon, cloves, and bay leaf, letting them sizzle for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

04 SAUTÉ THE ONION AND TOMATO

Add the sliced onion and cook until translucent, about 5 minutes. Add the chopped tomato, turmeric, and chili powder, cooking until the tomato softens, about 5 minutes.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Building the Kurma, continued

05 ADD THE COCONUT PASTE

Stir in the coconut-cashew paste and curry leaves, along with some of the reserved vegetable cooking water. Simmer for 8–10 minutes, stirring frequently since nut-based gravies can catch on the bottom of the pan.

06 ADD THE VEGETABLES

Add the boiled vegetables and salt, and simmer for a final 5 minutes to let everything meld together.

Texture indicator. the finished kurma should be a pale, creamy curry, thick enough to coat the vegetables but still pourable.

07 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with fresh coriander just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Cooking the coconut-based gravy over high heat is a common cause of scorching, since nut and coconut pastes catch more easily than tomato-based sauces. Keep the heat medium-low and stir frequently.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served with idiyappam (string hoppers), appam, or plain dosa, a classic South Indian breakfast pairing.
- Also served with rice or chapati for lunch or dinner.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl alongside a stack of idiyappam or appam, garnished with fresh coriander.

Family Style

- A mild, crowd-pleasing curry that works well for gatherings with a range of spice tolerances.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Richness Right

- A thoroughly smooth coconut-cashew paste is essential for the dish's signature velvety texture.
- Boiling the vegetables separately, rather than in the curry itself, keeps their texture cleaner and prevents overcooking.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The coconut-cashew paste can be made a day ahead and refrigerated, speeding up final cooking.
- This curry reheats reasonably well, making it a practical make-ahead dish for a busy week.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some South Indian restaurants add a few drops of rose water or a pinch of garam masala for a more Mughlai-inflected version, closer to the dish's North Indian roots.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

180 kcal	4 g	16 g	12 g	4 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Tamil-Style Vegetable Kurma	the classic version featured here, mild and coconut-forward.
Kurma with Paneer	some households add paneer cubes for extra protein and richness.
Spicy Kurma	an adjusted version with extra green chili for those who prefer more heat.

Why did my kurma turn grainy?

Usually the coconut-cashew paste wasn't blended smoothly enough. Blend thoroughly, adding water gradually, until completely smooth.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this without cashews?

Yes — a little extra coconut, or a small amount of poppy seed, can substitute, though the texture will be slightly different.

Is vegetable kurma very spicy?

No — it's one of the milder South Indian curries, making it a good introduction for those new to the cuisine.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Kurma	a braised curry style adapted from North Indian Mughlai cooking into a coconut-based South Indian version.
Idiyappam	steamed rice noodle "string hoppers," a classic pairing for this dish.
Appam	a lacy, bowl-shaped fermented rice pancake, another common pairing for kurma.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot oil, sometimes used to finish this dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Vegetable Kurma

15m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

VEGETABLES

Carrot	60 g
Green beans	50 g
Potato	80 g
Peas	70 g
Cauliflower florets	100 g
Water	240 ml

COCONUT-CASHEW PASTE

Fresh coconut	50 g
Cashews	25 g
Green chili	2
Fennel seeds	3 g
Ginger	10 g
Garlic cloves	3

CURRY

Oil	45 ml
Cinnamon stick	1 inch
Cloves	3
Bay leaf	1
Onion	100 g
Tomato	100 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Red chili powder	1.5 g
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
Salt	6 g
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Boil the vegetables.** Combine the carrot, beans, potato, peas, and cauliflower with water in a pot.

02 **Make the coconut-cashew paste.** Blend the coconut, cashews, green chili, fennel seeds, ginger, and garlic with a little water to a smooth, thick paste.

03 **Bloom the whole spices.** Heat oil in a kadai and add the cinnamon, cloves, and bay leaf, letting them sizzle for about 30 seconds until fragrant.

04 **Sauté the onion and tomato.** Add the sliced onion and cook until translucent, about 5 minutes.

05 **Add the coconut paste.** Stir in the coconut-cashew paste and curry leaves, along with some of the reserved vegetable cooking water.

06 **Add the vegetables.** Add the boiled vegetables and salt, and simmer for a final 5 minutes to let everything meld together.

07 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with fresh coriander just before serving.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Carrot	60 g
☐ Potato	80 g
☐ Cauliflower florets	100 g
☐ Cashews	25 g
☐ Fennel seeds	3 g
☐ Garlic cloves	3
☐ Cinnamon stick	1 inch
☐ Bay leaf	1
☐ Tomato	100 g
☐ Red chili powder	1.5 g
☐ Salt	6 g
☐ Green beans	50 g
☐ Peas	70 g
☐ Fresh coconut	50 g
☐ Green chili	2
☐ Ginger	10 g
☐ Oil	45 ml
☐ Cloves	3
☐ Onion	100 g
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g

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